



SWAN STAGE

In 1596, a Dutch visitor named Johannes de Witt sketched the Swan playhouse, giving us the only image from that time of a Shakespearean stage. It is bare apart from a bench. The scene might be set anywhere, from a palace to the deck of a ship.

director in charge of a production. The players knew what was expected of them, and they worked out the staging together.

PLAYING SOLDIERS

When players rushed on stage in full armor, waving swords, the audience knew that they were watching a battle. If the players carried scaling ladders, as in *Henry V*, the battle became a siege. In all their battle scenes, even those set in ancient Rome, the players used the latest weapons and armor.

Staging a play

PLAYS AT THE GLOBE theater were performed in the afternoons, by daylight. There was only a limited amount of scenery, but there were some wonderful special effects. Angels and gods were lowered from the "heavens," and devils and ghosts came up through a trapdoor in the stage. Philip Henslowe, the owner of the Rose playhouse, had "a frame for the heading" for pretending to behead a man on stage. At the back of the stage, there was a curtained-off area used for displaying "discoveries" – picture-like scenes, such as characters lying dead or asleep. There was no

Morion, a type of Spanish helmet



Rapier was used for fencing



Dagger was used in the left hand

Rapier was kept in a scabbard that hung from the belt



PLAY PLOT

The "platt," or plot, of a play was stuck on a board and hung on a peg backstage. It listed the scenes, with the exits and entrances of all the characters. During a performance, the players needed to refer to the platt because they had not read the whole play. Each player

was given only his own part to learn. This is the platt for *The Seven Deadly Sins, Part Two*, performed at the Theatre from 1590 to 1591.

"Our statues and our images of gods ... Our giants, monsters, furies, beasts and bugbears, Our helmets, shields, and vizors, hairs and beards, Our pasteboard marchpanes and our wooden pies ..."

RICHARD BROME

List of playhouse properties in *The Antipodes*



SPILLED BLOOD

Pigs' or sheeps' blood was sometimes used to add gory realism to scenes of violent death. In one play, *The Rebellion of Naples*, a character had a fake head cut off. The head contained a pig's bladder, filled with blood, which gushed all over the stage.

CONVINCING DISPLAY

A "beheaded man" could be shown on stage using two actors and a special table. This illusion would be set up in the "discovery space" at the back of the stage. Hidden hands would pull back the curtains, revealing to the audience what looked like the body of a man, with his head cut off and displayed at his feet.

